IB Economics - Topic 4.9: Teacher and AI Grading Guide

Barriers to Economic Growth and Development | Questions 1-50

Scope and assessment status

Each original paired question has (a) 10 marks and (b) 15 marks. All 50 questions assess shared SL/HL content. Difficulty: 10 Easy, 25 Medium, 15 Hard pairs, distributed through the bank. Level and difficulty are independent.

Poverty traps and specified economic, geographical, political and social barriers to growth and development. All shared SL/HL.

The uploaded Economics for the IB Diploma textbook (second edition, 2012) was used for conceptual verification. The current guide controls this topic's numbered scope and HL boundaries.

These are original adapted Paper 1-style practice questions, not official IB examination or marking material. The question bank revisits syllabus mechanisms through distinct explanatory and evaluative tasks; the pairs are alternatives for practice, not separate official learning outcomes.

Coverage blueprint

Poverty cycles: Questions 1-10

Economic barriers: Questions 11-20

Geography health: Questions 21-30

Institutions: Questions 31-40

Synthesis: Questions 41-50

Marking principles

Use best-fit assessment for each part, not a fixed marks-per-keyword checklist. Credit accurate alternatives addressing the task. Do not require every example or qualification below.

Part (a): 10 marks

Practice bands: 0; 1-2 limited; 3-4 mainly descriptive; 5-6 partial explanation; 7-8 clear and accurate causal analysis; 9-10 fully developed explanation with any required diagram or calculation. These abbreviated bands are not official IB descriptors.

Part (b): 15 marks

Practice bands: 0; 1-3 very limited; 4-6 superficial; 7-9 developed but weakly balanced; 10-12 balanced analysis and evaluation; 13-15 sustained, applied evaluation and supported judgment. A named case alone is not developed application.

Diagram and AI grading

For each diagram explicitly requested, credit an economically correct alternative with proper axes, equilibrium or reference lines, directions of change, and interpretation. Numerical responses require method, units and an explanation; do not award a final number with a contradictory mechanism.

Record separate marks for (a) and (b), band evidence, diagram or numerical features if relevant, economic misconceptions, quality of real-world application, and one actionable improvement per part. If a student drawing is unclear, flag the uncertainty rather than assuming correctness.

Question 1

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Using a poverty-cycle diagram, explain how low income can limit household saving and investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether saving constraints alone explain persistent poverty.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. Show a closed causal loop with at least four specific labelled links from the question, for example low income, low saving, low investment, low productivity and back to low income. Each arrow must describe a causal change, not just list problems.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 2

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Using a poverty-cycle diagram, explain how poor health can reinforce low productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether health programmes can break a poverty trap.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Ill health lowers labour capacity and income, limiting access to care.

Expected diagram or calculation. Show a closed causal loop with at least four specific labelled links from the question, for example low income, low saving, low investment, low productivity and back to low income. Each arrow must describe a causal change, not just list problems.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Ill health lowers labour capacity and income, limiting access to care.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 3

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Using a poverty-cycle diagram, explain how limited schooling can perpetuate low wages.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether education alone can end intergenerational poverty.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Low household resources reduce learning and skills, which suppress later earnings.

Expected diagram or calculation. Show a closed causal loop with at least four specific labelled links from the question, for example low income, low saving, low investment, low productivity and back to low income. Each arrow must describe a causal change, not just list problems.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low household resources reduce learning and skills, which suppress later earnings.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 4

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain how weak tax revenue can reinforce inadequate public infrastructure.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether foreign aid can break a public-finance poverty cycle.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Low output yields low receipts and underinvestment, limiting future productive capacity.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low output yields low receipts and underinvestment, limiting future productive capacity.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 5

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain how lack of collateral can reinforce low business investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether microfinance is sufficient to escape a poverty trap.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Low wealth restricts credit and capital, preventing productivity gains.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low wealth restricts credit and capital, preventing productivity gains.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 6

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Using a poverty-cycle diagram, explain how low agricultural productivity can maintain low rural incomes.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether improved farm technology necessarily breaks the cycle.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Low yields reduce income and investment in inputs, with land and markets as further constraints.

Expected diagram or calculation. Show a closed causal loop with at least four specific labelled links from the question, for example low income, low saving, low investment, low productivity and back to low income. Each arrow must describe a causal change, not just list problems.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low yields reduce income and investment in inputs, with land and markets as further constraints.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 7

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain why a shock to household earnings can have long-term effects when savings are low.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether temporary cash support can prevent lasting poverty.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Without a buffer, families may sell assets or withdraw children from school.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Without a buffer, families may sell assets or withdraw children from school.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 8

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain how poor sanitation can contribute to a cycle of low productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether clean-water infrastructure yields only health benefits.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Disease reduces work and learning; low incomes limit safe infrastructure finance.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Disease reduces work and learning; low incomes limit safe infrastructure finance.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 9

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain why a poverty cycle can persist despite some national GDP growth.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether aggregate growth necessarily reaches excluded regions.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Gains may bypass poor households lacking assets, transport or skills.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Gains may bypass poor households lacking assets, transport or skills.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 10

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Poverty cycles

(a) [10] Explain how discrimination may reinforce an intergenerational poverty cycle.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether legal equality alone can interrupt this cycle.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Low income constrains saving, capital formation and future productivity, while credit and institutions matter.

Required reasoning. Unequal access to jobs and education reduces earnings and future opportunities.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes poverty cycles from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Unequal access to jobs and education reduces earnings and future opportunities.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why poverty cycles may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 11

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how rising income inequality can restrict access to human capital.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether inequality necessarily slows growth.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 12

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how inadequate transport infrastructure can constrain domestic markets.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether building roads alone creates development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. High delivery costs reduce market access; complementary institutions and maintenance matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. High delivery costs reduce market access; complementary institutions and maintenance matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 13

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how limited access to suitable technology can lower labour productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether imported technology is useful without local skills.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Appropriate equipment can raise output, subject to affordability and training.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Appropriate equipment can raise output, subject to affordability and training.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 14

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain why a lack of health care can limit human capital.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether health investment can raise growth quickly.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Disease reduces attendance and work capacity; benefits can be long term.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Disease reduces attendance and work capacity; benefits can be long term.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 15

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how dependence on primary commodities exposes an economy to unstable export earnings.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether resource abundance is necessarily a barrier to development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Price swings transmit to income and public budgets, while governance can change outcomes.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Price swings transmit to income and public budgets, while governance can change outcomes.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 16

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain why limited access to international markets can restrict an exporting firm's scale.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether trade liberalisation alone raises development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Small markets constrain specialisation; logistics and standards also limit exports.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Small markets constrain specialisation; logistics and standards also limit exports.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 17

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain why a large informal economy can limit tax revenue.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether formalisation always benefits workers.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Unregistered activity is harder to tax, but informal work can provide livelihoods.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Unregistered activity is harder to tax, but informal work can provide livelihoods.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 18

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how capital flight can reduce funds available for domestic investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether capital controls solve underlying causes.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Outward financial flows can lower local funding, reflecting risk or weak institutions.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Outward financial flows can lower local funding, reflecting risk or weak institutions.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 19

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how high external debt-service costs can crowd out development spending.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether debt relief always increases productive investment.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Repayments absorb fiscal resources; reallocation depends on governance and creditors.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Repayments absorb fiscal resources; reallocation depends on governance and creditors.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 20

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Economic barriers

(a) [10] Explain how a shortage of reliable electricity can limit industrial diversification.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether expanding power supply guarantees job growth.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Poor households may underinvest in schooling and health; some unequal rewards affect incentives.

Required reasoning. Unreliable energy raises costs and discourages production, with skills and finance still necessary.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes economic barriers from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Unreliable energy raises costs and discourages production, with skills and finance still necessary.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why economic barriers may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 21

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain why landlocked geography can raise international trading costs.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether landlocked countries are inevitably poor.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 22

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how long distances to ports can reduce export competitiveness.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether transport infrastructure can fully overcome geography.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Time and freight costs raise delivered price; logistics investment can mitigate.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Time and freight costs raise delivered price; logistics investment can mitigate.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 23

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how tropical disease burdens can affect labour productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether climate determines an economy's development level.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Illness and care costs reduce productive time, while public health can limit effects.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Illness and care costs reduce productive time, while public health can limit effects.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 24

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how drought can undermine farm earnings and public finances.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether climate adaptation can protect development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Lower yields cut income and taxes; irrigation and diversification may reduce exposure.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Lower yields cut income and taxes; irrigation and diversification may reduce exposure.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 25

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain why a country exposed to frequent natural hazards may struggle to accumulate capital.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether disaster risk makes investment unproductive.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Repeated asset loss diverts resources from new capital to replacement.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Repeated asset loss diverts resources from new capital to replacement.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 26

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how poor soil quality can limit agricultural productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether farming constraints necessarily prevent diversification.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Low yields reduce income, but technology and non-farm sectors can offer routes.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Low yields reduce income, but technology and non-farm sectors can offer routes.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 27

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain why access to navigable transport routes can influence industrial location.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether geography is more important than institutions.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Lower logistics costs encourage firms, while rules and skills also matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Lower logistics costs encourage firms, while rules and skills also matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 28

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how water scarcity can constrain manufacturing and household welfare.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether better pricing alone can solve scarcity.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Water is an input and basic need; infrastructure and sustainability matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Water is an input and basic need; infrastructure and sustainability matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 29

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain why a country's resource endowment does not by itself determine development.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether resource-poor economies can grow rapidly.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Productivity, institutions and trade can offset resource scarcity.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Productivity, institutions and trade can offset resource scarcity.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 30

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Geography health

(a) [10] Explain how climate-related disease can reduce school attendance.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether a health intervention can also improve future earnings.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Goods cross borders and inland routes, but corridors and regional agreements can help.

Required reasoning. Illness disrupts learning and human capital; access and quality of schooling matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes geography health from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Illness disrupts learning and human capital; access and quality of schooling matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why geography health may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 31

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how weak property rights can discourage long-term investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether formal titles alone secure property rights.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 32

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain why an unreliable legal system may reduce business formation.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether legal reform always attracts investors.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Contract uncertainty raises risk and transaction costs; other barriers persist.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Contract uncertainty raises risk and transaction costs; other barriers persist.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 33

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how ineffective tax administration can constrain public services.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether raising statutory tax rates solves low revenue.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Weak collection limits receipts; enforcement and trust influence compliance.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Weak collection limits receipts; enforcement and trust influence compliance.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 34

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain why a poorly functioning banking system may limit investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether expanding credit always promotes development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Intermediation channels saving to productive uses, but bad loans can create instability.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Intermediation channels saving to productive uses, but bad loans can create instability.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 35

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how corruption can reduce the value of public infrastructure spending.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether more aid is effective without accountability.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Diversion and poor procurement reduce actual service delivered.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Diversion and poor procurement reduce actual service delivered.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 36

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how unequal political power can affect allocation of public resources.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether elections alone guarantee inclusive development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Elites may influence spending and regulation, limiting access for poorer groups.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Elites may influence spending and regulation, limiting access for poorer groups.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 37

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain why insecure land rights can discourage farmers from improving productivity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether formalising land ownership always benefits smallholders.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Risk of dispossession shortens investment horizon; customary rights and access matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Risk of dispossession shortens investment horizon; customary rights and access matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 38

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how gender inequality can lower participation in paid work.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether removing formal barriers is enough to expand women's opportunities.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Discrimination and care burdens can exclude talent; services and norms matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Discrimination and care burdens can exclude talent; services and norms matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 39

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain why limited banking access can reduce household resilience to income shocks.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether mobile banking can substitute for a strong financial system.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Savings and payment access buffer shocks, but regulation and trust are needed.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Savings and payment access buffer shocks, but regulation and trust are needed.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 40

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Institutions

(a) [10] Explain how bribery can alter the allocation of business licences.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether deregulation alone reduces corruption.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Uncertain ownership reduces incentive and collateral, while enforcement is essential.

Required reasoning. Officials may allocate by payments rather than productivity; transparency and enforcement matter.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes institutions from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Officials may allocate by payments rather than productivity; transparency and enforcement matter.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why institutions may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 41

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain how inadequate roads can reinforce the effects of poor schooling.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether solving one development barrier at a time is sufficient.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 42

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain why a country with abundant minerals may still have high poverty.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether the resource sector can support inclusive growth.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Export income may be concentrated and volatile; institutions determine public benefit.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Export income may be concentrated and volatile; institutions determine public benefit.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 43

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain how weak institutions can amplify the damage from a natural disaster.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether geography is more important than governance.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Poor planning and enforcement increase exposure and slow rebuilding.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Poor planning and enforcement increase exposure and slow rebuilding.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 44

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain why access to foreign markets may not help firms with unreliable electricity.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether trade policy should precede infrastructure investment.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Market access has limited value when producers cannot meet quantity or quality demands.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Market access has limited value when producers cannot meet quantity or quality demands.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 45

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain how high debt and weak tax collection can jointly constrain public investment.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether debt relief is sufficient for long-run development.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Debt service drains budget while collection shortfalls limit alternatives; reforms may need both.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Debt service drains budget while collection shortfalls limit alternatives; reforms may need both.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 46

Easy | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain why gender barriers can intensify a low-human-capital poverty cycle.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether educating girls yields benefits beyond their future wages.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Exclusion reduces skills and household health, with spillovers to later generations.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Exclusion reduces skills and household health, with spillovers to later generations.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 47

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain how capital flight may reflect rather than solely cause weak institutions.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether stopping outflows would automatically raise productive investment.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Risk and insecurity trigger exit; controls without reform may not create viable projects.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Risk and insecurity trigger exit; controls without reform may not create viable projects.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 48

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain why commodity-price shocks can hurt both private earnings and government services.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether diversification is an effective response.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Export revenue and fiscal receipts fall together, transmitting shock to investment and public spending.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Export revenue and fiscal receipts fall together, transmitting shock to investment and public spending.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 49

Hard | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain how several barriers can produce a self-reinforcing development trap.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, discuss whether a single policy can break a multidimensional trap.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Weak health, skills, infrastructure and finance interact, requiring priorities and coordination.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Weak health, skills, infrastructure and finance interact, requiring priorities and coordination.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Question 50

Medium | SL/HL | 25 marks

Topic 4.9: Synthesis

(a) [10] Explain why the importance of a development barrier depends on a country's context.

(b) [15] Using real-world examples, evaluate whether one global ranking of barriers can guide all countries.

Part (a) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Essential concepts. Economic, social, institutional and geographical constraints can reinforce a low-income poverty cycle. Specifically: Travel costs limit access to schools and jobs, compounding skills constraints.

Required reasoning. Geography, institutions, endowments and history determine which constraint is binding.

Expected diagram or calculation. If requested, draw the correct syllabus model, label axes, initial and changed equilibria, and explain the specific mechanism in the question.

Common misconceptions. Distinguish price-level changes from exchange-rate changes, flows from stocks, and an observed correlation from a demonstrated causal effect. Do not require a neighbouring topic as essential knowledge. For this question, check specifically that the student distinguishes synthesis from nearby concepts and does not reverse the stated causal relationship.

Acceptable alternatives. Credit any other accurate economic argument, diagram or real-world example that directly addresses the specific question. Do not require a single policy conclusion or named case.

Part (b) - Indicative answer and marking guidance

Main argument. Geography, institutions, endowments and history determine which constraint is binding.

Counterargument and conditions. A barrier may be reinforced by other constraints; identifying the most binding one requires country evidence. For this focus, consider why synthesis may have a different effect across countries.

Application and real-world example. Use a named country and World Bank/UNDP development indicators to connect a particular barrier with a plausible causal mechanism. Credit any accurate alternative example.

Evaluation and judgment. A strong response applies the example to the stated mechanism, weighs the qualification against the main argument, and reaches a conditional conclusion. Its conclusion may differ from the suggested route if the economics and case are sound.

Sources and scope

The current IB Economics guide controls syllabus boundaries. The uploaded Economics for the IB Diploma, second edition (2012), is a supplementary conceptual check; its older chapter sequence and content cannot expand the current specification. Real-world examples are optional and should be checked against their cited sources.

IB guide. Current Economics guide, Unit 4 Topic 4.9; syllabus scope, diagrams, calculations and SL/HL boundaries.

Open source

World Bank. Development indicators for contextual country comparisons.

Open source

UNDP. Human development dimensions and country data.

Open source

Final checks

50 paired questions; 10 Easy, 25 Medium, 15 Hard; All 50 questions assess shared SL/HL content. The student paper contains no answers or difficulty labels.